Chapter 8

Novel Methods, Novel Results: Beginning of Welfare Policing

IN 1980 BOOTLEGGING WAS RAMPANT IN DELHI, WITH A CARTEL OF big-time smugglers and wholesalers getting liquor from across the borders and peddling it on the streets of Delhi. The Sansis were an erstwhile criminal tribe, declared as such during the British days, and had been traditionally involved in bootlegging. The members of this community were the people used by the cartel to further their criminal business. As deputy commissioner, West District, Kiran Bedi interacted with these tribals and involved herself in the process of their rehabilitation in non-criminal fields. With patient and persuasive counselling and by winning the confidence of the community, this menace was successfully removed from the streets of Delhi. This, in fact, was her first exposure as a correctional police officer, which she was at heart. Incidentally, the Ramon Magsaysay award (which she won in 1994) citation begins with the correctional work done by Kiran as a police officer before she came into the limelight for carrying out prison reforms in Tihar Jail, New Delhi.

Reproduced below is a news item that appeared in this context:

REFORMED SANSIS HELP BRING DOWN CRIME RATE

Incidence of bootlegging in West District appears to have declined following the 'voluntary' decision by the Sansis of Madipur [a village in west Delhi] some months back to give up liquor distilling and to take up 'legal' profession.

Though no planned jobs have been created specially for them, many Sansis have begun taking up new trades. According to Mrs Kiran Bedi, Deputy Commissioner of Police, West District, the fall in bootlegging had resulted in an appreciable drop in related crimes.

The problem of 'connivance' still poses a major problem as even well-planned and executed schemes imposed from the top can run aground due to dishonesty in some pockets, she said. 'Policemen are not all that innocent.'

In the last few months, according to Mrs Bedi, about 10 officers and constables, detected while accepting 'protection money' or believed to be conniving with illicit still operators, had been suspended. 'These things cannot exist without police connivance and it is here that rooting out of bad elements must begin,' she said.

(*The Times of India*, 1 November 1980)

* * *